

BAROQUE MUSIC

PERIOD OF WESTERN ART MUSIC FROM 1600 TO 1750

Baroque music is a period or style of Western art music composed from approximately 1600 to 1750. This era followed the Renaissance music era and was followed in turn by the Classical era. The word baroque is derived from the Portuguese word 'barroco', meaning misshapen pearl, initially used to describe overly ornate architecture. The Baroque period saw the creation of tonality and the establishment of the major-minor key system that dominated Western music for the next 300 years. Composers began writing with specific key signatures and developing harmonic progressions that created tension and resolution. Major characteristics of Baroque music include the use of complex tonal counterpoint, the increased use of dissonance, the rise of the solo voice with accompaniment, and the development of the concerto, sonata, and opera as major musical forms. The doctrine of the affections held that music should express specific emotions. Johann Sebastian Bach stands as perhaps the greatest composer of the Baroque era. His works synthesized German, French, and Italian musical styles. The Brandenburg Concertos, The Well-Tempered Clavier, and the Mass in B minor represent the pinnacle of Baroque compositional art.

George Frideric Handel achieved tremendous popularity with his operas and oratorios. His Messiah remains one of the most frequently performed choral works. Handel's music combined Italian melodic genius with German contrapuntal mastery and English choral tradition. Antonio Vivaldi revolutionized the concerto form. His Four Seasons concertos remain among the most recognizable pieces of Baroque music. Vivaldi wrote over 500 concertos, establishing the three-movement fast-slow-fast structure that became standard. Opera flourished during the Baroque period. Claudio Monteverdi's *L'Orfeo* (1607) is generally regarded as the first great opera. Opera seria and opera buffa developed as distinct genres, with elaborate vocal displays showcasing singers' virtuosity.

The Baroque era ended with Bach's death in 1750, though some overlap existed with the emerging Classical style. The period's emphasis on ornamentation, counterpoint, and emotional expression left an indelible mark on Western music, influencing composers for centuries to come.